8. The Emergence of a Chinese Cultural Sphere

We have seen how medieval China, over time, became a rival Buddhist universe, with its own sacred places associated with Buddhist deities. These attracted pilgrims from beyond the borders of the Middle Kingdom of the time. There were famous Chinese monk-scholars who introduced doctrinal refinements on the basis of the scriptures obtained from India in an earlier period and translated into Chinese by both Chinese and Indian scholars.

The four major Chinese schools of Buddhism, as mentioned in the previous chapter, were the Qing tu (Pure Land), Huayan (Flower Garden), Tiantai (Celestial Platform) and Chan (Zen). These different schools of Buddhism then became the vehicles through which Chinese culture was transmitted to some of the neighbouring countries like Korea and Japan, and to parts of Vietnam. These countries then became part of a larger ‘Sinosphere’, or Chinese sphere of cultural influence in Asia. The origins of the faith in distant India persisted in memory during these transmissions, but India was perceived more as an idealized ‘Western Paradise’, a term already used by Chinese Buddhists to describe the sacred birthplace of the Master. In Japan, for example, India was known as Tenjiku, a Japanese transliteration of the Chinese phrase ‘Tianzhu’. The Chinese characters mean the ‘Pearl of Heaven’, but they could also be a transliteration of the term ‘Sindhu’ (the river Indus) by which India was known in its western periphery. There were occasional monks from India or from the oasis towns in Central Asia who found their way to these new Buddhist centres.

The Chinese *Book of Liang* , which is the dynastic history of the Liang dynasty (502–557 CE), carries an account of ancient Japan, then known as Fusang. It says that in 467 CE , five Buddhist monks from the Gandhara region travelled to Japan with Buddhist scriptures. There are records of an Indian monk, Bodhisena, who carried out the ‘abhisekha’, or consecration